Thief River

By Lee Blessing

Background: Ray's son is getting married; Gil shows up out of the blue, with his new lover, Kit. Gil is Ray's best friend from twenty years before, and his first and only love.

INTRODUCTION

Actor 1: We may not be your neighborhood high school lovers whose romance culminates in an at long last happy ending,

Actor 2: Neither do we have any steamy sex scenes or indulge in any questionable on-stage nudity.

Actor 1: But whatever your sexual orientation, Lee Blessing's take on love is universal and less about sex than about the courage to live a full life rather than a safe but half life.

Actor 2: After all, the way you fall in love is "one confession at a time."

TOGETHER: Thief River by Lee Blessing

RAY: What's his name again?

GIL: Kit.

RAY: Kit? That what you made him out of?

GIL: He's sharing my life right now. I'm not surprised you forgot his name.

RAY: It was sort of hard to hear while we were dragging him from under the pews.

GIL: I'm so sorry for that. I never meant to—

RAY: Jesus Christ, Gil. What in the hell are you doing? What are you doing? (BEAT)

How can you be with that?

GIL: You don't even know him.

RAY: I know he's half your age.

GIL: You think I should be with someone appropriate?

RAY: Yes!

GIL: Like Molly? (As Ray gives him a hard stare) We're really kind of an adorable couple. You should come visit us sometime.

RAY: I don't think so.

GIL: We're very quiet at home. He wants to move, and I don't--that's about the biggest issue.

RAY: You'd be so lucky to be rid of him.

GIL: Of course, I suppose there are a lot of men who'd be delighted to have someone to settle for at all. Not Kit, though. He's too beautiful. So am I. So are you. We shouldn't have to settle.

RAY: I'm a married man.

GIL: Does your son know about me?

RAY: No.

GIL: He really wanted to kill me today.

RAY: I wanted to kill you myself. I haven't seen you in twenty years, and this is how you--?

GIL: I said I'm sorry—

RAY: Sorry? For Christ's sake, what were you thinking?! Why on earth did you come up here?

GIL: Twenty years. It has been that, hasn't it? And every week, for twenty years, you wrote me a letter. What were you thinking?

RAY: Those letters were about how I could not be with you.

GIL: "I cannot be with you." Once a week, every week, twenty years. They came no matter what. Even after you got married and asked me to stop writing back. Made no difference. The letters kept coming. Monday morning. "How about that? A letter from Ray."

RAY: They were a kind of meditation. Like writing in a journal.

GIL: Oh, I was supposed to meditate? Didn't realize. "I love you, Gil"--that was in every letter. Was I supposed to meditate on that? Or how about, "Gil, you should see the hillside behind Logan's Drug. It's covered in wild roses."

RAY: Why are you here?

GIL: First, I apologize for what happened at the wedding rehearsal. I had no idea that was today, and I had no idea that Kit would—

RAY: Why are you here?!

GIL: Isn't it obvious? You stopped writing. (Ray changes the subject; softens his voice)

RAY: Look at Perry with that horrible kid of yours. What on earth you think they're talking about?

GIL: Kit's very well read in certain areas. What's Perry know about lingerie?

RAY: If they're talking flannel, everything. Perry can sit and listen to anybody about anything. Listens to all sides, too. That's pretty rare up here--well, you know.

GIL: Maybe we should've died here. Like a pair of great lovers.

RAY: Most patient man I know.

GIL: Who?

RAY: Perry. Haven't you been listening?

GIL: Haven't you?

RAY: I can see why you want to be with me. It's like we're married already.

GIL: Like we always have been. We'd be such a great couple. We wouldn't have to live in Brooklyn Center. I wouldn't make you do that.

RAY: We sure couldn't live here.

GIL: We'd go to New York; we'd both be lost. We'd be this aging gay couple, holding hands on the sidewalk, no matter how corny it looked--except at night, when the kids from Jersey with the baseball bats show up.

RAY: Where do you get all this?

GIL: I read.

RAY: Believe me, you're making New York sound real attractive.

GIL: It is! You can say, "I'm gay," and—in general--they won't kill you. (Ray gives him a rueful smile)

RAY: Where'll I put all my personal things.

GIL: Personal things?

RAY: You know--wife, son...(Gil goes silent)

GIL: Trunk. Open it up once a year on Christmas.

RAY: Doesn't sound fair.

GIL: I was there first.

RAY: No, you weren't. I was going with Molly—

GIL: (Pointing to Ray's heart) I was there. First. (BEAT) Why'd you stop writing me?

RAY: My son's getting married.

GIL: So?

RAY: Twenty years. What was I doing? Who was I doing it for? I didn't know anymore. I couldn't...Nobody can live on that, Gil. It's a ghost. (BEAT) Besides, I have to be a family man. I have to be for them, or I'm not...for them.

GIL: Hard to be articulate when you don't believe what you're saying.

RAY: I don't expect you to understand—

GIL: Why? 'Cause I didn't make a fake family?

RAY: It's not fake!

GIL: You are. Every week, when you write that letter, you are fake. No. I take it back. That's the one time you're genuine.

RAY: What we had was over a long time ago—

GIL: It's not over. You know, maybe I wish it was over too, but it isn't.

RAY: Gil—

GIL: If it was over, you'd have shoved Kit and me back in our car and told us to get the hell out. But you didn't. Look where we are, Ray. Look where we're standing.

RAY: You know the kind of questions that are going through my family's minds right now?

GIL: I'm sorry.

RAY: You destroyed the rehearsal. I suppose I'm lucky you didn't stumble in here tomorrow and ruin the real thing.

GIL: I don't pretend I know what I'm doing here. Any more than you know--really--why you stopped writing. All I know is that I have questions. About us. I need the answers. You know, it's totally different out there. The way we grew up...here...you're right, we probably couldn't have done it, but now...I can be a person out there. So can you. And it's only going to get better—

RAY: You're with Kit.

GIL: And you're with Molly, but I don't see them here.

RAY: I can't rip up everyone's life around me.

GIL: You're better off lying to them?

RAY: Why not? It was better to lie. She earned that lie. All she's ever done is love me. (BEAT) I won't leave them. I won't leave my son.

GIL: He's a grown man. He's getting married. Besides, he hates people like us.

RAY: Ray Junior's his own person--all right? I mean, you walk in all unannounced with that...that creature—

GIL: He's not a "creature"—

RAY: My son's never seen anybody like that, he's never been around—

GIL: And that gives him the right to throw Kit over a pew? What the hell kind of values did he grow up with,Ray?

RAY: Our values! This town's values! I did what I could, I told him everyone's a human being; that doesn't mean he has to listen to me. He's got his own mind. I can't

change that--I wouldn't change it. Why in the hell did you bring Kit in the first place?

GIL: I didn't want to. He insisted. He lives with me,Ray. You think I can hide how I feel? He's jealous and he's just trying to fuck everything up in his own, adorable little way.

RAY: And he doesn't matter to you?

GIL: I don't know. That's what I'm saying. That's why I'm here. I want to find out. I want to know, if you and I can—

RAY: We can't. (BEAT) We won't. You and Kit get in your car. Get out of here.

GIL: God sees us, Ray.

RAY: Will you get out?

GIL: God sees us.

RAY: When did you get religious?

GIL: I didn't. But God sees what He made. I don't need religion to know that. (Holds his hand up, studying it) My body is religion. Each cell. What I know in each cell. It's all we are: billions--trillions?--of cells. Each one with a wall. Each and every one. Trillions of walls. That's what we're mostly made up of. Walls.

RAY: Some of us are mostly made up of horseshit.

GIL: But which ones? (BEAT) Say you don't love me. Say it. I'll go. (SILENCE)

RAY: Some nights, when Molly's asleep--in the same room, in the same bed where you and I first...I'll get up, and...I'll go downstairs. I have to walk way on the far edges of the steps so they don't creak, and...eventually I'll get downstairs. And I'll see the living room. You remember that day in the living room.

GIL: Yes.

RAY: And if it's summer I'll go out on the porch. And I'll just sit there on the rail, where we sat. That night you first held my hand. In the dark. For an hour. (BEAT) And then I'll go back upstairs to bed. Some nights, I can even fall asleep again.

(BEAT) In the morning Molly's always so pretty. Always so rested. She has so much energy.

GIL: Molly's a strong woman.

RAY: She is.

GIL: She'd survive losing you.

RAY: You don't know a thing about it. I married her. We had a son. That's it--that's my life. I take care of them.

GIL: What if it comes out?

RAY: What?

GIL: You and me.

RAY: It's not going to come out—

GIL: I could make it come out.

RAY: If you did, you'd never hear from me again.

GIL: What have I got to lose?

RAY: She'd never believe you.

GIL: I have your letters, Ray. I brought them with me. Boxes and boxes.

RAY: You didn't. You did not bring those letters.

GIL: Actually, I did. Glad I took the hatchback. They just fill it up. Go out and check if you want.

RAY: I want 'em back.

GIL: Sorry, they're my property.

RAY: They're mine! They were private, to you. They're who I am inside. They're not for other-Jesus, Gil.

GIL: Maybe I'll put 'em in the paper. Or hell--my travel editor might know somebody. "Gay Journal From The Heartland." What do you think?

RAY: It'll take away everything. I won't have them; I won't want you. Is that how you want it?

GIL: Is it worse than what I've got?

RAY: My whole life I've lived without you. We've lived different from each other.

GIL: You'll change.

RAY: I can't.

GIL: You change every day! You change in the time it takes to write a letter. You change whenever you dream. Whenever you think about me.

RAY: What do you want? What do you want me to do?

GIL: I want us to take a week. You could come down to the Cities. You can tell Molly something, I'll tell Kit something. We can stay in a hotel and just...see.

RAY: I can't be gone a week.

GIL: Maybe not a whole week. Maybe a couple of days. It might not take that long. We could realize right away that it's not going to work—

RAY: No excuse would sound right to Molly.

GIL: If you don't find out now, when are you going to? Now's the time, Ray. Now's the chance. Don't let it all just...flow away again.

RAY: What do you think's going to happen in a few day's time in a hotel? (BEAT) Is life even real to you, Gil? Do you care how many people you--?

GIL: No. I don't care. Want to know why? 'Cause nobody up here ever once asked themselves, "What does Gil need? What's his deepest wish in life?"

RAY: They're not responsible for—

GIL: They were sitting in this town, all warm and toasty and accepted, while I was in the hospital, or down in the workhouse, or scraping my way through three abusive college relationships--all with guys that looked exactly like you—

RAY: We never—

GIL: A few days. Together. Then you decide. I promise I won't bother you again.

RAY: No one sees the letters?

GIL: I didn't bring the letters.

RAY: What?

GIL: I didn't bring them, I was...I was lying. I need you to come.

RAY: Christ.

GIL: I had to think of a way. That's all. It was stupid.

RAY: That's an understatement. Where are my letters?

GIL: In my dresser, at home. I'll burn them if you want We can burn them together.

RAY: You saved 'em all? Every one?

GIL: Yeah.

RAY: Twenty years?

GIL: I could tell you what it is in shoeboxes. (BEAT) Well, tell Ray Junior I'm sorry. Tell him congratulations for me. (Starts to walk away)

RAY: I'll come down.

GIL: What?

RAY: Can only be a couple days—

GIL: That'd be all right.

RAY: You sure?

GIL: Whatever you can spare. Are you sure?

RAY: (BEAT) Yeah.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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